



TEMPLES OF THE FROGFOLK



Pelgrane Press

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TEMPLES OF THE FROGFOLK

Every age of the world ends in apocalypse. The races that dominate the Dragon Empire today are the races resilient or lucky enough to survive the catastrophes that annihilated their less fortunate brethren.

The fabled serpent folk who ruled the lands before the Wizard King are perhaps the best known of these vanished peoples, but scholars in Horizon also speak of the mosquito-men of the KneeDeep, the bandaged deadfolk of the eastern shore, the infamously vile marrow-eaters, the cryptic race that raised crystalline pillars all through what is now the Red Wastes, and the salamander-people who descended into the blazing tunnels beneath the Magma Keeps, never to be seen again.

Judging from the manner in which historians and Imperial administrators almost completely ignore them, you might imagine that the secretive race known as the “frogspawn” or the “frogfolk” sunk into the swamps ages ago alongside the mosquito-men. But it's not so. The frogspawn still hop and croak in the swamps, but scholars of the 13th Age seldom speak of them.

Inquiries concerning the frogfolk are usually met with brush-offs and more-or-less truthful statements that the frogspawn hardly matter. The even stranger truth is that human, elven, and dwarven scholars more-or-less agree that nothing good has ever come of speaking or writing about the frogspawn. It's not that the frogspawn themselves are so powerful. But somehow terrible and weird things seem to happen to all the historians, bards, and scribes who have seriously considered the frogfolk in past eras. Those who speak about the frogfolk usually end up dying mysteriously, sometimes in ways that seem related to frogspawn, sometimes not. There's apparently some great curse at work, but no one claims to understand it. The frogspawn seem like such a minor frayed thread in the world's great tapestry that none of the great powers seem to have troubled themselves to unravel the mystery.

We'll reveal as much as we can about the frogfolk in this essay, but if you hear any strange noises outside your window, or there's an unexplained *moistness* in the air, or you hear some strange unnatural croaking, don't hesitate—RUN!

13 REASONS TO BE PARANOID....

We aren't going to delve into all the possible sources of the supposed frogspawn curse. As we said, that way lies madness. We'd rather save *madness* for your campaigns to hash out!

But we can dig into frogfolk psychology, even if we aren't quite certain of the source of the curse.

Why are the frogfolk so paranoid and secretive? Have they always been this way? Of course they're never going to tell

you straight out. They're paranoid and secretive! So any of the following could be true....

- The Diabolist-sponsored plague that ended the 12th Age was spread by frogspawn. The frogfolk were hunted to the brink of extinction, and now they hide from the world in case vengeful agents of the Crusader try to finish the job.
- The frogfolk know something about one of the icons, a secret that would forever change the Dragon Empire if it were ever revealed. They're in hiding from the servants of that icon until the time comes when the truth can be revealed.
- That thing you heard about the Diabolist and the Prince of Shadows collaborating on some big project? Frogspawn are the result of that collaboration, though they may be more of a side effect than the intended result.
- Properly prepared, frogspawn skin exudes hallucinatory toxins that promise visions of the future. Drug dealers, servants of dark gods, oracles, and visitors from other realities enslave or skin frogspawn when they can find them. And so the frogspawn try not to be found.
- The gods hate the frogfolk. *All* the gods, even the meekest and most forgiving of the Gods of Light. The frogs aren't part of any divine plan—they bubbled in from some alternate dimension, and they're like a spiritual poison. If one of the frogfolk worships a god, its reverence poisons the deity. The only thing to do is make sure the frogs never find religion.
- Or maybe the frogfolk are the remnants of some former divine plague, a living weapon that rained down from the overworld to bring devastation and sorrow to the lands below. They're hiding from their creators.
- Toadstones, gentle reader. Toadstones! The frogfolk hide because whenever they come to the surface, greedy adventurers pry their foreheads open looking for magic gems.
- The frogfolk are not native to the Dragon Empire—they came here in a shining starship that crashed in the swamps, or maybe they folded space and time to come here from another dimension.
- Or they were *made* by visitors from another place, and are trying to ensure that the secrets of their vanished creators are not profaned.
- They're biologically incapable of *not* being paranoid and fearful, any more than an owlbear can choose not to hunt or a wyvern not to sting. Player character frogfolk must fight against their instinctive urge to murder anyone who sees them.
- PCs searching for the source of the frogspawn curse first learn that more than one age has ended when someone succeeded in uncovering the secret. It must be a coincidence.
- There's some link between the frogspawn and the tarrasque. By all means, investigate!
- We've said too much. The frogs are here!

FROGSPAWN

Survivors of frogspawn ambushes develop a nervous habit of poking at calm swamp water with ten-foot poles. Preferably with sharp points attached.

SPECIAL ABILITIES FOR ALL FROGSPAWN

As a hidden threat, the frogspawn should be allowed to surprise the PCs at least twice during a campaign. Instead of pegging specific abilities to specific frogspawn, we'll start with a list of froggy abilities that can be added to any of the frogspawn monsters that follow.

You should certainly use one ability per frogspawn, occasionally two. For frogspawn mooks, treat the abilities as usable once per battle.

If you're in the mood for frogspawn super-swamp ninjas in a climactic battle, you might use three abilities piled onto one monster.

Disgusting tongue: The frogspawn deals poison damage equal to its level to any character that pops free of it or successfully disengages from it. (Teleporting away is probably tongue-free unless the GM is hopping mad.)

Dunk and cover: If the battle is taking place in a swamp, lake, or river, whenever the frogspawn misses with a natural even attack roll, it can duck out of sight. Remove the frogspawn from the table until the start of its next turn. At the start of its next turn, place it anywhere nearby its previous location, but not engaged with an enemy.

Erratic leap: If the frogspawn is unengaged at the start of its turn, choose a random nearby enemy the frogspawn can see. The frogspawn leaps into engagement with that enemy as a move action, and its crit range with melee attacks expands against that enemy by 3 until the end of the turn.

Paranoid destroyer: This frogspawn can't be surprised. If there's a surprise round, it gets to act. If there isn't a surprise round at the start of combat, the frogspawn gets a surprise round if its natural initiative roll is 16+. On the downside, subtract 2 from this frogspawn's MD, because it's always sure it's going to die. (**Gamemaster:** Don't give this ability to all the frogspawn in a battle. Just one or two.)



FROGSPAWN GRUNT

2nd level mook [HUMANOID]

Initiative: +6

Frogspear +6 vs. AC—6 damage

Nastier Specials

Poisoned spears: When using a frogspear, a natural attack roll of 16+ inflicts 3 ongoing poison damage.

AC 16
PD 15
MD 11

HP 7 (mook)

Mook: Kill one frogspawn mook for every 7 damage you deal to the mob.

FROGSPAWN MONK

These fanatical assassins consume a concoction of rare fungi and toad juices before going into battle, to sharpen their reflexes and flood their bodies with poison. As a side effect, the monks lose all fear of death or pain, become willing to take absurd risks, and hallucinate wildly.

3rd level spoiler [HUMANOID]

Initiative: +8

Flailing frog fists +8 vs. AC—8 damage, or 12 damage if this is the first time the frogspawn monk has attacked the target this battle

Poison burst: When a frogspawn monk is slain, it may make a *poison burst* attack as an interrupt action.

[Special trigger] **C: Poison burst +8 vs. PD (all enemies engaged with the monk)**—5 ongoing poison damage

AC 18

PD 18

MD 14

HP 45

FROGSPAWN SPELLCROAKER

As these magicians bellow and croak, a disconcerting luminescence billows in their pale throats. When you look across the swamps and see a cluster of pale lights pulsing in the distance, know that some less fortunate traveler is trapped in a frogspawn nightmare.

4th level leader [HUMANOID]

Initiative: +8

Frogspear +9 vs. AC—13 damage

R: Curseblast +9 vs. MD (one nearby or far away enemy)—13 damage, and if a target is staggered by this attack, the spellcroaker may make another *curseblast* attack immediately against a different target

C: Eruption of frogs +9 vs. PD (all engaged enemies)—5 ongoing poison damage, and the target pops free of the spellcroaker
Limited use: 1/battle.

Croaking chorus: At the start of each round, all spellcroakers in a battle start to croak together in chorus. This imposes a special bonus or penalty depending on the croak generated by the chorus that round (roll 1d6).

1–2: *Croak of dismay:* If the number of spellcroakers is equal to or greater than the value of the escalation die, then the player characters do not get the benefit of the escalation die; all frogs may add the value of the escalation die to their attack rolls instead.

3–4: *Croak of victory:* All attacks by frogfolk gain a bonus to damage equal to the number of spellcroakers.

5–6: *Croak of choking:* Over the course of the round, you may force the player characters to reroll a number of d20 rolls (attack rolls, saving throws, skill checks, death saves) equal to the number of spellcroakers.

When a spellcroaker is slain, roll a d20. On an 11+, the remaining spellcroakers are able to maintain the *croaking chorus* for the rest of the round. Otherwise, the chorus effect is cancelled for the rest of that round.

Nastier Specials

Croakmaster: This spellcroaker counts as two spellcroakers for the purposes of the *croaking chorus*.

Frog curse: If a spellcroaker rolls a natural 18+ when using a *curseblast*, the target is transformed into a steadily shrinking frog-like humanoid and is hampered and weakened (save ends all effects). If the curse somehow ran its full course, the target would no doubt shrink down into a frog, but PCs are made of strong stuff and should be able to evade a fate that might affect common folk.

AC 18

PD 19

MD 17

HP 50

FROG KNIGHT

As they wear rusty armor salvaged from paladins and warriors who drowned in the mud, frog knights might seem absurd at first glance. Keep laughing through your new sucking chest wound when they've skewered you.

5th level blocker [HUMANOID]

Initiative: +8

Shillelagh +10 vs. AC—18 damage

Lance +10 vs. AC—25 damage, and 5 ongoing damage (save ends)
Limited use: 1/battle.

Leap to the defense: Once per round, if a frog knight is unengaged, and an ally is targeted by an attack against AC anywhere on the battlefield, the frog knight may immediately leap to its ally's side and give that ally a +2 bonus to AC for the rest of the round as an interrupt action.

Nastier Specials

Heavy armor: Once per battle, when struck by an attack that targets AC, take half damage from that attack instead.

Poisoned spikes: On a natural 16+, a shillelagh hit inflicts 5 ongoing poison damage (save ends).

AC 22

PD 20

MD 14

HP 100

MUTANT BULLFROG

It's unclear if these are giant mutant horned frogmen, or giant mutant horned frogs bred and trained by frogmen. Or perhaps the distinction is nugatory, as we must immediately flee for our lives lest we be gored and eaten.

Large 5th level wrecker [BEAST]

Initiative: +8

Gore +10 vs. AC—20 damage

Natural even hit: The bullfrog may also make a *bite* attack as a free action.

C: Tongue grab +10 vs. PD (one nearby target)—15 damage, and the target pops free of whomever it is engaged with now and moves to be engaged with the bullfrog

Natural even hit: The bullfrog may also make a *bite* attack as a free action.

[Special trigger] **Bite +10 vs. AC**—20 damage

Natural 16+: If smaller than the mutant bullfrog, the target is partially swallowed, and takes 10 ongoing damage (disengaging or popping free ends).

[Special trigger] **C: Bellow +10 vs. PD (1d3 nearby enemies)**—20 thunder damage

Roar of pain: The bullfrog *bellows* as a free action when first staggered or when the escalation die becomes even.

Nastier Specials

Frenzy: The bullfrog may add the escalation die to its attack rolls when staggered.

AC	18	
PD	20	HP 200
MD	14	

TREASURES OF THE FROGFOLK

Batrachites (aka toadstones): These curious magical crystals grow naturally from the skulls of certain frogfolk. (They're commonly called "toadstones," and the sort of sage who knows the technical term for these crystals is invariably also the sort who'd haughtily correct you if you mixed up "frog" and "toad" when discussing how you obtained such treasures). The commonest *batrachite* is the purple stone; others are found much more rarely. A stone can be inset into a pendant (in which case it gives the usual necklace bonus to all saves when your hit points are low, but takes up the neck chakra slot) or carried as a wondrous item (in which case it doesn't occupy a chakra slot).

Purple toadstone (recharge 16+): Automatically succeed at a saving throw against ongoing poison damage. Quirk: Likes to try exotic drinks.

Blue toadstone: As long as you possess this stone, you won't drown. That doesn't mean you can breathe water—it just means that you won't die from drowning. As soon as you return to the surface, you'll spontaneously cough up all the water you swallowed and find yourself mostly unaffected by your ordeal. Quirk: Night terrors.

Green toadstone (recharge 11+): You share in the natural paranoia of the frogfolk. You gain a +4 bonus to skill checks to spot ambushes, and, if surprised, you may act in the surprise round. Quirk: Rampant paranoia.

Yellow toadstone (recharge 16+): You can fight in spirit even in a fight you're involved in, as long as your only other action in a round is to make a death or last gasp save. Basically, if you're dying, the stone kicks in and charges your ebbing spirit with magical energy. Quirk: Has visions of distant places.

Cursed black toadstone (recharge 6+): The exceedingly rare black toadstones are crystallized spiritual poison. They poison the bonds between gods and their followers, between rulers and their subjects, between friends and allies. However, just as a fever can give a sick man unnatural strength, a poisoned bond can give surprising benefits to the character who bears the stone.

- **Divine Spells:** Reroll a failed attack roll with a divine spell.
- **Icon Relationship Rolls:** Treat a roll of a 1 as a 6.
- **Allies:** If you and an ally are both suffering from the same condition, you may automatically succeed at your next save against that condition, but your ally automatically fails his or her next save against that condition.

Keep track of the number of times you use the toadstone against a particular deity/icon/ally. Each time you roll to recharge the stone, if your roll is equal to or less than the number of times the stone has been used against a particular individual, then that individual suffers the equivalent of a campaign loss—a significant weakening, defeat, or stroke of ill-fortune. This resets the count for that individual. Quirk: Extremely selfish.

BOOTS CHAKRA

Frogskin Leggings of Leaping (recharge 11+): You may make astounding leaps and jumps. Once per battle, as a move action, roll a d20. If you roll 3+, you may place yourself in a nearby location you can see. If you roll a 1 or a 2, the GM chooses the spot you've jumped to based on what would be funniest or most interesting. You must be barefoot to wear these leggings, and they take up the chakra slot usually reserved for boots. Quirk: You need to keep your skin moist. Dryness means death!

GLOVE CHAKRA

Toadskin of Insight (recharge 11+): Lick this leathery bracelet to fill your mind with visions. You become confused (save ends), but gain a +1 bonus to all attacks targeting MD for the remainder of the battle. Quirk: Spouts absurd philosophical "insights."

Wondrous Item

Muck Seed: This curious and wondrous item resembles a fist-sized glob of dark clay that glitters with magical energy. You can work the *muck seed* into whatever rough shape you wish, then throw it into any mutable substance—a swampy mire is ideal, but it would also work on a muddy field, wet sand, flowing lava, or a gelatinous cube. The substance immediately reshapes itself to match the shape of the *muck seed*. So, you could conjure a rough mud “castle” from a bog, or make a solid road through a swamp. The *muck seed* is reusable, but you’ve got to dig it out of the mire if you want it back. Quirk: You’re unable to say “good enough”—you keep making tiny changes and tweaks to any act of craft or artistic creation. Also, the swamps eventually absorb the seed, and sometimes the frogspawn learn a bit more about you as you use the seed than you’d like them to.

ENCOUNTERS

FROGFOLK AMBUSH

This encounter might represent a frogfolk patrol near one of their temples. Add in a few more monks if you want to turn it into a frog assassination squad. The frogspawn monks attack first, of course, jumping into the middle of the fray and pinning the adventurers so the frogspawn grunts can hop in second and skewer. Any spellcroakers, if present, lurk in the background flinging curses and using the *croaking chorus*.

Keep the frogspawn moving. Pop free whenever possible, then hop back into the fray to take advantage of those incredible leaps.

Number/ Level of PCs	Frogspawn Grunts	Frogspawn Monks	Frogspawn Spellcroakers
3 × 2 nd level	6	1	0
4 × 2 nd level	6	2	0
5 × 2 nd level	9	2	0
6 × 2 nd level	9	3	0
7 × 2 nd level	9	3	1
3 × 3 rd level	6	1	0
4 × 3 rd level	9	2	0
5 × 3 rd level	9	2	1
6 × 3 rd level	9	2	2
7 × 3 rd level	9	3	2

FROG TEMPLE

Fun fact—the collective noun for frogs is an *army* of frogs, and that’s exactly what you’ve got here, guarding one of their temples. At lower levels, the knights start by attacking with their lances, then shift to walloping with shillelaghs. Any grunts are there to just be meatshields for the spellcroakers, who croak in the hopes of generating a *croak of dismay* (if encountered *inside* the temple itself, consider using the *croakmaster* nastier special). If there’s a bullfrog present, the knight uses it as a mount, at least at the start of the fight.

Number/ Level of PCs	Frogspawn Grunts	Frogspawn Spellcroakers	Frog Knights	Mutant Bullfrogs
3 × 3 rd level	4	1	1	0
4 × 3 rd level	4	2	1	0
5 × 3 rd level	8	2	1	0
6 × 3 rd level	8	2	2	0
7 × 3 rd level	8	2	1	1
3 × 4 th level	5	1	2	0
4 × 4 th level	10	2	2	0
5 × 4 th level	10	3	2	0
6 × 4 th level	10	3	1	1
7 × 4 th level	10	3	2	1

TEMPLES OF THE FROGS

Rather than give you a single temple of the frogs, how about five of them, each associated with a different icon? You should only use one of these—after all, the frogfolk are in hiding, so having the adventurers run into two or three different hidden temples run by a supposedly extinct race beggars belief (unless, of course, the frogfolk are playing some froggy long con on the icons, each colony of frogs claiming to be the sole survivors ...). You’ll find suggestions for frog-free versions of the temples at the end of each write-up.

One fact unites all these disparate temples of the frogfolk—secrecy. Remember, it is whispered that anyone who talks openly about frogfolk ends up dead. The temples of the frogs may be the graves of the adventurers if they are unwary.

THE ARCHMAGE: FORGOTTEN TEMPLE

Somewhere on the eastern fringe of the Empire, there's a river that's called simply the New River. A few hundred years ago, a titanic storm blew in from across the Iron Sea—a once-in-an-age cataclysmic storm, the sort that floods cities and shatters harbors. The Archmage (not the current Archmage, but his predecessor) bound the storm with magical chains. The storm's still there, squeezed into a raging, roiling ball of dark clouds, stuck in a secret valley. The ceaseless rains from the chained storm birthed the New River.

There's also a swamp, called Shadow Swamp, in the shadow of those eternal storm clouds. (No one had much time to spare for great names for a river and swamp they wanted to just forget about!) The frogfolk dwell in that swamp, but their temple isn't there. It's a flying temple, hidden in the storm above. The forgotten temple was once a place of crystal and steel and mysterious gizmos (either magi-tech or genuine hi-tech, depending on your taste), but it's now covered in rust, moss, and swamp gunk. To get to the temple, you go to the very middle of Shadow Swamp, where you'll find a huge pile of rocks. Climb the rock pile, then (assuming you don't get hit by lightning), jump straight up and grab onto one of the vine strands that hang down out of the clouds. Of course, to pull that off, you'll need to be able to jump like a frog.

Did the Archmage just use the chained storm cloud as a convenient hiding place, or does the forgotten temple somehow control the weather around it?

Historical option: The previous Archmage grew ... let's be polite here ... "eccentric" toward the end of her life, and that's eccentric by the standards of the Archmage. She knew she was dying. She knew who her replacement was destined to be. And she *hated* her replacement. Before she vanished, she deliberately destroyed or hid certain key records in Horizon, including any direct references to the forgotten temple. The Archmage's servants might know there's *something* interesting in Shadow Swamp, but don't know exactly what it is.

Current politics: A further complication is the blue dragon Azhela, who discovered the permanent storm and the forgotten temple a few months ago. She's set herself up as ruler of the frogfolk while she studies the structure and the wards that hold the storm in place. Some of the frogfolk hate and fear her; others see her as their salvation. Any connection between the crazy former Archmage and an oddly well-informed and magically talented blue dragon are left as an exercise for the GM.

Frog-free variant: The previous Archmage dumped one of her experiments in creating new life in the forgotten temple. These Dwellers are human-ish, but have transparent flesh and organs, so they look like jelly-covered bones.



THE CRUSADER: BOG OF SINNERS

The Crusader is without mercy.

He does, however, allow for redemption.

A slain foe is useless to his cause. A defeated foe can be enslaved, or converted, or put to work, or at the very least sacrificed to the Dark Gods in exchange for power. The Bog of Sinners is his special prison for demonologists and sorcerers who trafficked with the forces of hell, and the frogfolk are his secret jailers. Captured spellcasters get buried upside down in the mud. *Water breathing* spells (or *blue toadstones*) keep them alive while they're force-fed by unseen frogfolk, but it's impossible to cast a spell with a mouth full of mud and hands bound behind your back. Once a prisoner finally cracks and submits to the Crusader's cause, the frogfolk drag the new convert to their temple to the Dark Gods for ritual branding.

This arrangement has worked so well that the Crusader's servants have stopped paying attention to the frogfolk. Every time they capture a demonologist, they just send the wretch off to the Bog of Sinners for conversion by the frogs, and don't bother checking up. So, they haven't noticed that the frogfolk's worship of the Dark Gods has become more fervent, or that they're sending far fewer spellcasters back to the Crusader's legions these days....

Investigating any potential treachery on the part of the frogfolk is tricky. Their temple is somewhere deep in a trackless swamp that only they can navigate. Any adventurers sent to

investigate will have to pretend to be condemned spellcasters, then escape and infiltrate the temple, and maybe then defeat the frog cult before they do something ghastly in the name of the Dark Gods.

Frog-free variant: Instead of frogfolk, just make them renegade servants of the Crusader.

THE PRIESTESS: SECRET SHRINE

This scenario works best with our admittedly weird "frogfolk worship is divine poison" take. The Priestess maintains a secret temple in the Wild Wood near Santa Cora. There, she shelters the remaining frogfolk from the fear and hatred of the wider world. The gods—all the gods—have turned their backs on the frogfolk, but the chosen servant of all the gods has chosen to protect and foster the frogfolk instead. What's going on?

The adventurers are recruited by one of the Priestess's acolytes who has begun to have doubts about his mistress's plans. Is the Priestess trying to find a way to break the curse of the frogfolk so they can worship the Light? Or is she planning to pair the frogfolk with a god that's strong enough (or suicidal enough) to endure the poison of their veneration? Maybe she's keeping the frogfolk in reserve as a weapon against the Dark Gods? Or could the Priestess be the harbinger of a godless age, an age where mortals alone decide the fate of the world? Just what, the acolyte asks, is she preaching in there?

Frog-free variant: Holy ones cut off from the Light? Religious fey? Undead devotees of a dead god?

THE PRINCE OF SHADOWS: FROGHAVEN PORT

The old charts do say "Froghaven," but surely that's just a smudge, because everyone knows it as Foghaven. According to stories told in the taverns of Shadow Port, it's a mist-shrouded island somewhere east of Omen. If you've got the blessing of the Prince, you'll find Foghaven just when you need it—like when you're shipwrecked and drifting with the currents, or being chased by a flotilla of elven warships out of Concord.

None of the old charts agree on where Foghaven lies. It's almost as if the island moves, as if it was a floating clump of earth, or maybe a giant frog with forests and swamps clinging to its back. Some visitors to Foghaven claim that the "fogs" are clouds of millions of huge black flies that swarm around the shores so thickly that you can't see your hand in front of your face, or for that matter the hand of the frogspawn that's about to stab you in the chin.

There's a small port on Foghaven, a place of smugglers and vagabonds and strangely frog-like natives who stare at you with bulging eyes. Visitors are warned not to go inland. Sometimes, the natives emerge from the interior carrying jars of poison and other strange concoctions, trade goods bound for Shadow Port and Drakkenhall and beyond. They farm toads on the island, crossbreeding poisonous species to create ever weirder toxins.

The temple's somewhere in the middle of the island, guarded by the frogfolk. The frogfolk made a bargain with the Prince, long ago—if he helped them hide from their persecutors, they'd serve him.

So, how can the players mess that up in an interesting way? Firstly, you need to get them to Foghaven. An icon relationship benefit from the Prince (especially a one-shot one garnered from a bard song or some other temporary bonus) might let shipwrecked PCs wash up on the shores of Foghaven. There, they meet a sailor who's fallen in love with a local island "prince" (or better yet, one of the PCs falls in love with the islander). Secretly, the island prince is a frogfolk who wants to see the world beyond the island, and has used a spell of illusion to appear human. The frogfolk elders get wind of this scheme and drag the would-be lover back to the temple. The adventurers must sneak into the temple on a rescue mission. A kiss breaks the illusion and turns the prince into a frogfolk, but true love (and judicious application of fireballs against hordes of murderous frogspawn) conquers all.

Frog-free variant: Any monstrous humanoid works perfectly well here—renegade twygzogs, maybe?

THE THREE: TEMPLE OF ELDRITCH SORCERY

The reason you don't encounter frogfolk in the same numbers as lizardmen or kobolds is because of a magical catastrophe. Some frogfolk, the spellcroakers, have a natural gift for magic that far exceeds most of their ilk. During the last age, they developed a new spell of terrible power, the *chant of doom*. It broke free of their control. They couldn't stop casting it and, well, they croaked.

The few surviving frogfolk are now under the control of the Black dragon. The Black is jealous of her sister's magical power, and cultivates the frogfolk as a potential way of counterbalancing the Blue's sorcery. If that disastrous spell from the 12th Age could be refined and mastered—under carefully controlled conditions, of course—it might tip the balance of the Three towards the Black. The frogfolk temple is a magical research facility, working with an incantation that even the Diabolist would consider dangerous.

Of course, for such a spell to be useful to the Black, it has to work for spellcasters who aren't frogfolk. There just aren't enough spellcroakers left, so the spell must be adapted for other races. The Black's assassins and monks kidnap unwary spellcasters and drag them away to the secret temple, where they're forced to learn the *chant of doom* and cast it in specially warded dungeons beneath the mire.

GAMEMASTER

(One of the marvelous things about the 13th Age spell system is that you can give even a low-level PC a unique spell that'll end the world—if prepared as a 9th level spell. At 1st or 3rd level, it's just a bunch of damage).

FROGFOLK PLAYER CHARACTERS

+2 Dex OR +2 Con

Frogfolk are rare and mistrusted; you might be the only frogfolk adventurer in the world, and unless you disguise yourself, you're going to run into prejudice and fear in most "civilized" places.

Alternatively, of course, your one unique thing and backgrounds might create a story in which you are the unique frogfolk who walks proudly through the halls of the Empire.

LONG STICKY TONGUE (RACIAL POWER)

Once per battle as a free action, when an enemy successfully disengages or pops free from you, you may grab them with your sticky tongue and automatically re-engage with them. It doesn't work if the enemy teleports away. You can also use your tongue to filch nearby items, grab onto objects, or nab a tasty fly.

Adventurer Feat: You automatically inflict 5 ongoing poison damage (save ends) when you use your tongue.

Champion Feat: You may now use your tongue more than once per battle, but must succeed at a save (11+) after each use in order to use it again.

By a strange mischance (a blow to the head, a mystic vision, a spell gone awry), one of the player characters suddenly remembers being abducted by agents of the Black and carried away into the swamp. The adventurer realizes that she knows the *chant of doom*. What does the spell do? Did the adventurer escape, or did the frogfolk let her go? If so, why? Did they deliberately intend for her to carry the chant away? Why has the memory returned now? And most importantly, how can she get the spell of doom out of her head? The answers to all these questions can be found somewhere in the temple of the frogs....

